GAME DESIGN DOCUMENT

HELLO OWNER

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1. Game Overview

Title: Hello Owner
Genre: First-Person Psychological Horror
Platform: PC
Engine: Unreal Engine
Perspective: First-Person
Role: Solo Developer
Development Status: Completed

Hello Owner is a narrative-driven psychological horror experience where the player takes a late-night warehouse job to earn extra money. What begins as routine labor slowly escalates into a supernatural trap tied to ownership, greed, and inherited guilt.

The game prioritizes **environmental storytelling, audio-driven tension, and rule-based environmental systems**, deliberately avoiding combat or traditional survival mechanics.

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2. Core Fantasy

"You are just doing your job — but the place decides whether you're allowed to leave."

The player's fear emerges from:

- Familiar work tasks becoming hostile
- Gradual loss of environmental control
- Being silently observed, tested, and judged by the space itself

The horror is not introduced through monsters, but through **obedience, routine, and restriction**.

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3. Design Pillars

1. Normalcy Before Horror

The game begins grounded and believable. Horror escalates gradually through subtle disruptions.

2. Audio-First Fear

Sound design communicates danger, timing, and progression more than visuals or jumpscares.

3. No Combat, Only Consequences

The player cannot fight back. Survival depends on observation, restraint, and listening.

4. Environment as an Antagonist

The warehouse actively changes, blocks, tests, and punishes the player.

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4. Core Gameplay Loop

1. Receive an objective
2. Perform a warehouse task (move boxes, navigate space)
3. Environmental changes occur
4. Audio and visual anomalies escalate
5. Player explores to progress
6. Player decisions influence narrative outcome

This loop repeats with **rising psychological pressure**, not mechanical difficulty.

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5. Player Mechanics

Movement

- Standard first-person movement
- Intentionally slow pacing
- No sprint abuse or evasive mechanics

Interaction

- Pick up and place boxes
- Collect keys
- Open doors, shutters, cupboards
- Use switches and buttons

UI

- Objective UI (minimal, task-focused)

- Call UI (diegetic phone interactions)
- Minimal HUD during gameplay
- Full pause menu with:
    - Controls
    - Graphics
    - Audio
    - Scene loading (skip replaying completed sections)

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6. Box Mechanic — Primary Task System

Boxes represent **labor, obedience, and ownership**.

Early Game Use

- Introduced safely during Truck 1
- UI displays:
    - Target placement location
    - Remaining box count
- Teaches:
    - Pickup and placement controls
    - Navigation flow
    - Task completion structure

Late Game Use

- Boxes transform into:
    - Environmental obstacles
    - Chase elements
    - Narrative punishment tools

In specific endings, falling boxes actively threaten the player.

This mechanic intentionally shifts from **mundane labor → symbolic punishment**.

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7. Progression Structure

Truck 1 — Tutorial Phase

- Normal environment
- No threats
- Focus on routine and mechanics

Truck 2 — Rising Tension

- Paranormal hints begin:
  - Whispers
  - Flickering lights
  - Distant rack movement
- Player continues due to monetary motivation

Truck 3 — Point of No Return

- Panicked call from the boss
- Blood and audio distortion
- Warehouse lockdown
- Maze sequence begins

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8. Rule-Based Environmental Systems (Maze Mechanic)

Purpose

The maze is not a puzzle to solve, but a **test imposed by the warehouse** to determine whether the player is worthy of ownership or destruction.

Maze Activation

- Triggered after interacting with Truck 3
- Lights shut down sequentially
- When lights return:
  - Warehouse racks reconfigure
  - Paths are blocked or opened

- Distinct red, unnatural lighting begins

Maze Objectives

To escape the lockdown, the player must:

1. Locate the Office Key
2. Discover documents revealing the warehouse's past
3. Find the Electric Room Key
4. Restore power
5. Discover a hidden path behind a sliding cupboard

Wrong paths are expected — and punished.

Lighting & Movement Rule System

Core Rule:

- **Lights ON (5 seconds):** Player may move
- **Lights OFF (3 seconds):** Player must remain completely still

Failure Condition:

- Moving during lights-off results in:
  - Immediate ghost capture
  - Respawn at checkpoint

This system enforces:

- Controlled movement
- Audio awareness
- Psychological pressure over reflex-based difficulty

Dynamic Rack System

- Warehouse racks are movable actors
- Racks:
  - Shift positions during lights-off phases

    - Block or reveal routes

The maze is **semi-scripted**:

- Core progression paths are fixed
- Minor variations prevent memorization

The environment actively resists escape.

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9. Audio Design

Audio is critical to survival.

Audio Functions

- Light-state timing cues
- Directional whispers
- Footsteps and distant movement
- Electrical hum near objectives
- Intentional silence as a tension tool

Players who listen carefully perform better than those who rush.

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10. Endings Overview

Ending 1 — *Framed*

Leaving without choosing a door.

Ending 2 — *The New Owner*

Accepting ownership and repeating the cycle.

Ending 3 — *Burn It Down* (True Ending)

Destroying the warehouse and breaking the cycle.

Each ending reinforces the theme of **choice versus greed**.

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11. Design Intent

Hello Owner explores psychological horror through:

- Labor

- Compliance
- Ownership
- Environmental control

The maze exists to **strip player agency**, not to challenge mechanical skill.

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12. Constraints & Design Tradeoffs

- No combat to maintain vulnerability
- Warehouse setting chosen for modular environmental control
- Minimal NPCs to reinforce isolation
- AI-generated voices used due to lack of access to professional actors

All constraints were intentional to ensure **full project completion** as a solo developer.

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13. Why This Project Matters

This project demonstrates:

- End-to-end Unreal Engine pipeline understanding
- Narrative-driven system design
- Rule-based environmental mechanics
- Audio-centric gameplay design
- Complete start-to-finish solo development

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14. Credits

Game Design & Direction: Kash
Narrative Design & Story: Kash
Gameplay Programming: Kash
Level Design & Environment Setup: Kash
UI / UX Design: Kash
Audio Design & Implementation: Kash

Voice Generation: ElevenLabs
Used for AI-generated dialogue due to lack of access to professional voice actors

Sound Effects & Ambience: Pixabay
3D Assets & Props: Unreal Engine Marketplace

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